

Mirror mirror

The mirror system on the A33 owes its origin to the Canon Pellix camera in 1965 that had a semi-transparent pellicle mirror

Outsourcing?

Nikon doesn't make their own sensors, and mostly use Sony ones. This includes the gigantic 24MP unit in the D3x, and the excellent low-light 16.4MP unit in the D7000

Michael Browne
Siddharth Chauhan
michael.browne@thinkdigit.com
siddharth.chauhan@thinkdigit.com

Like every other gadget, dSLRs are also slowly shrinking in size, while growing in performance. Advancements in sensor, lens and allied technologies mean increased resolution, dynamic range, sharpness, and high ISO performance. Although Canon, Nikon, Olympus and Sony are the

sors these dSLRs obviously outperform point-n-shoots priced similarly. You also get the flexibility of removable lenses, as well as access to high-end lenses that offer even more quality.

There are five cameras in this category – Canon EOS 1100D and 600D, Nikon D3100 and D5100 and the Sony A33.

Features and ergonomics

The Sony A33 is built decently, but not as good as the Canon and Nikon cameras in this segment. The quality of materials used is

find you haven't pressed the key hard enough. The mode dial on the 600D feels a lot more solid. While the 600D has a rubber grip that feels infinitely better, the 1100D has marginally larger buttons – a good thing.

In comparison, the D5100 is solidly built, and easily feels as well built as the Canon 600D, but is a bit narrower, while being a bit higher. Both these models are direct competitors, and both feature 3-inch, articulating LCDs, unlike their lower-end brethren.

ferent mirror arrangement. The mirror is now semi-transparent or translucent and reflects 66 per cent of light on to the sensor and the remaining to the viewfinder. This makes for a smaller camera, without space for the mirror flip-up, and also a faster camera. The minus is its sensor gets less light, as does the viewfinder, making the scene darker.

The D3100 and D5100 have similar control systems. Neither camera has any buttons on the left of the LCD and in this regard, Canon and Nikon are the same. The Nikon D3100 and D5100 have a similar menu system, and it's much more visual than Canon's system. For example, on Canon, changing ISO involves highlighting a number, but with Nikon, a helpful photo appears that indicates the kind of shooting setting best suited for the currently selected ISO. While pros will scoff at such a newbie system, first time dSLR

SIZE MATTERS

Sensor sizes, that is...
We've got 11 worthy
dSLRs in this test

only brands officially present in India, and Olympus has only one model currently available. We've covered all these brands, and got five cameras from Canon, four from Nikon and one each from Olympus and Sony.

ENTRY-LEVEL

These cameras are typically smaller, built of less exotic materials and offer less performance than their costlier counterparts. The biggest advantage is their smaller size. Such dSLRs start at around ₹25,000 – the same price as some high-end ultra compacts, ultra zoom cameras. However, with their larger sen-

good, but the same can't be said for the lens. The kit lens is shockingly tacky, their zoom mechanism isn't smooth. Canon's 1100D is well built, better than the previous EOS 1000D, but it lacks any sort of rubber grip, and has a smooth body to boot. Its polycarbonate shell feels robust and at par with Nikon's D3100. The D3100 is a bit smaller than the Canon 1100D and has a much better grip.

Quite surprisingly, the buttons on the 1100D feel softer and better to use than the costlier 600D, but in reality, with deeper key travel, they aren't as intuitive to use because at times you

The Nikon D3100 and Canon 1100D don't have an articulating LCD, while the Sony A33 does. Incidentally, the Sony A33 also has a dif-

users will find it useful.

The Sony A33 might be called a dSLR, but it's quite tiny, and the body design is nearly identical to the NEX-5 – Sony's "powerful compact camera" with removable lenses and a larger sensor. The A33 has the same APS-C size sensor with a 1.5x frame factor, and also a similar control system. Sony has tried to move away from the classic button and dial system, and the A33 has more on-screen menus and a lot of the settings involve pressing a button, then



Sony A33